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INSTALLATION GUIDE

CortexSkills

Install, start and run the training engineering platform on your computer

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Prepared by POWERACT Consulting

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1. What you need to know first

CortexSkills runs on your own computer as two small programs that work together: the server (it keeps the data) and the web application (the screens you use in your browser). You start each one in its own window with three short commands. No database, no internet account and no technical tool other than Node.js is needed.

Item	What it is
Node.js 22.13 or newer	The free engine that runs CortexSkills. You install it once.
server folder	Keeps the data (a file named cortexskills.db in server/data), the backups and the attached files.
web folder	The screens. You open them at http://localhost:5173 in Chrome, Edge, Firefox or Safari.
Demonstration data	58 organizations in 29 sectors, each with two full runs (Digital skills and AI skills), in English, French and Arabic.

Time needed

About 15 minutes the first time: 5 minutes to install Node.js, 5 minutes for the two installs, 1 minute for the demonstration data.

2. Install Node.js (once)

2.1 Windows and macOS

1. Open <https://nodejs.org> in your browser.
2. Click the button marked LTS (the recommended version, 22 or newer) and download the installer.
3. Run the installer and accept the default options until it finishes.
4. Restart your computer if the installer asks you to.

2.2 Linux

Install Node.js 22 LTS with your distribution's package manager or from nodejs.org. Then continue with section 2.3.

2.3 Check the installation

Open a terminal window. On Windows: press the Windows key, type PowerShell, press Enter. On macOS: press Cmd + Space, type Terminal, press Enter. Then type:

```
node -v
```

The answer must start with v22.13 or higher (for example v22.14.0). If it shows an older number, install the LTS version again.

3. Unzip the application

1. Copy the file CortexSkills-app.zip to a folder of your choice, for example Documents.
2. Right-click the file and choose Extract All (Windows) or double-click it (macOS).
3. Open the new CortexSkills folder. You see two folders: server and web, and a README file.

Tip

Keep the folder path short and without special characters, for example C:\CortexSkills or Documents/CortexSkills.

4. Start the server

The server must run the whole time you use CortexSkills. Keep its window open.

1. Open a terminal window (see 2.3).
2. Go to the server folder. Type **cd** followed by a space, drag the server folder onto the window, and press Enter.
3. Type the three commands below, one at a time, pressing Enter after each and waiting for it to finish.

```
npm install
npm run seed
npm run dev
```

Command	What it does	How long
npm install	Downloads the components the server needs. You do this only once.	1–3 minutes
npm run seed	Creates the demonstration data. It erases any existing data, so run it only the first time or when you want a fresh start.	About 1 minute
npm run dev	Starts the server. You do this every time you want to use CortexSkills.	A few seconds

When the server is ready, the window shows:

```
CortexSkills API is running on http://localhost:4000 (mode: saas)
Now start the web application: open the "web" folder and run "npm run dev".
```

5. Start the web application

1. Open a second terminal window. Leave the server window open.
2. Go to the web folder in the same way (cd, then drag the web folder, then Enter).
3. Type the two commands below, one at a time.

```
npm install  
npm run dev
```

The window shows a line with Local: <http://localhost:5173>. Open that address in your browser.



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The image shows a sign-in screen for the CortexSkills application. It has a light gray background. At the top left, the text "Sign in" is displayed in a bold, black font. To the right of "Sign in" are three buttons labeled "EN", "FR", and "AR". Below "Sign in" are two input fields: "Email" and "Password". Below the "Password" field is an orange button labeled "Sign in". At the bottom of the form, there is a line of small text: "Demonstration: admin@cortexskills.app / Admin#2026, or any organization user (for example headId@atlasmotorskenitra.ma) with CortexSkills#2026."

Figure 1 — The sign-in screen at <http://localhost:5173>

6. Sign in

All demonstration accounts use the same password, except the platform administrator.

Who	E-mail	Password
Platform administrator (all organizations)	admin@cortexskills.app	Admin#2026
Head of L&D, Large company — Automotive	headld@atlasmotorskenitra.ma	CortexSkills#2026
Head of L&D, SME — Automotive	headld@tangerautoparts.ma	CortexSkills#2026
Head of L&D, SME — AEC construction	headld@soussbtpolutions.ma	CortexSkills#2026
Head of L&D, SME — Healthcare	headld@cliniquealamal.ma	CortexSkills#2026

Every organization has one account per role. The address is the role name followed by @ and the organization's domain, for example hrd@atlasmotorskenitra.ma (HR Director), analyst@... (L&D Analyst), trainer@..., manager@..., finance@..., compliance@..., auditor@... (read-only). The full list is in Administration > Users when you are signed in as an administrator.

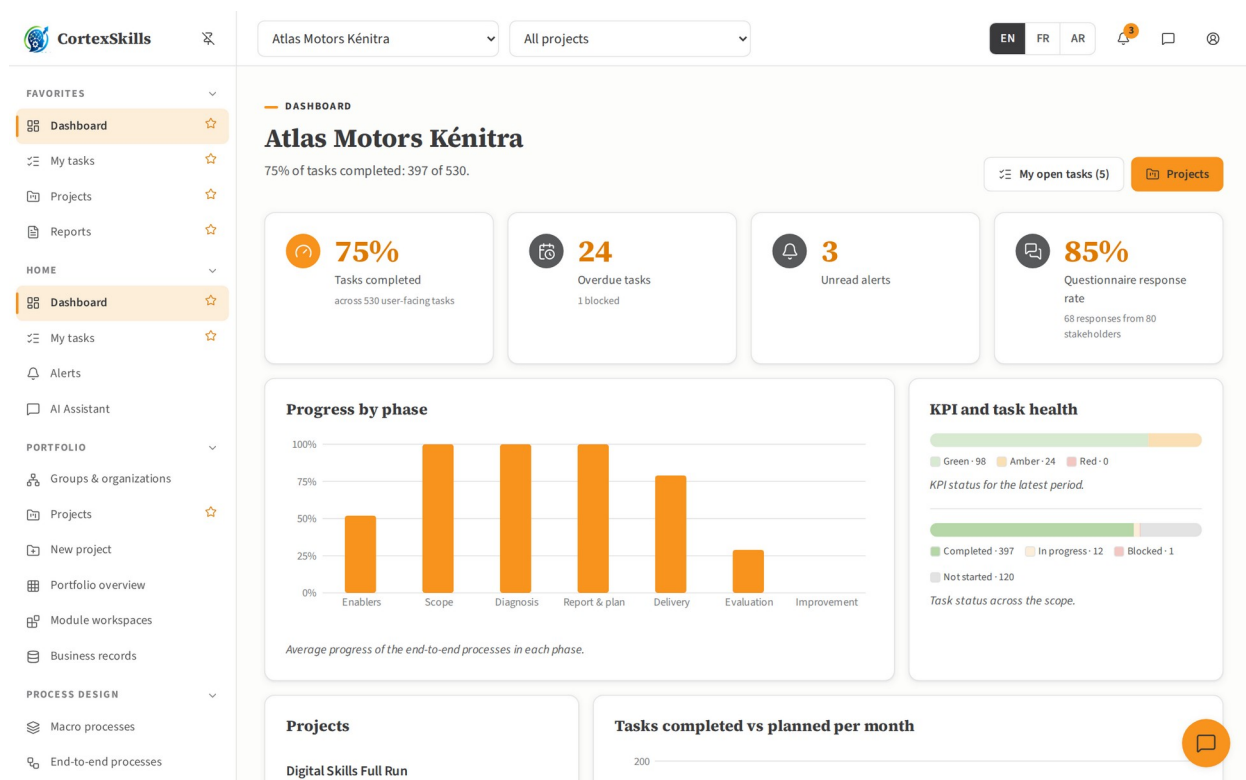


Figure 2 — The dashboard after sign-in

Choose your language at the top of the screen (EN, FR, AR). Arabic switches the whole application to right-to-left.

7. Everyday use

I want to...	Do this
Stop CortexSkills	In each of the two windows, press Ctrl + C. Your data is kept.
Start again tomorrow	Server window: cd to the server folder, then npm run dev. Web window: cd to the web folder, then npm run dev. Do not run npm run seed again.
Go back to the original demonstration data	Stop the server, run npm run seed in the server folder, then npm run dev. All your changes are erased.
Make a backup now	In the server folder: npm run backup. Or sign in as administrator and open Administration › Backups.
Use it from another computer on the same network	Use the address <code>http://<this computer's name or IP>:5173</code> in that computer's browser.

8. Backups, licence and AI model

8.1 Backups

The server takes a backup automatically once a day and keeps backups for 14 days. Backups are stored in `server/data/backups`. To restore one: stop the server, copy the backup file over `server/data/cortexskills.db`, and start the server again. A backup from an earlier version starts without any extra step.

8.2 Licence

In the default SaaS mode, each organization has a signed licence record created by the demonstration data. For an on-premises installation, set `DEPLOYMENT_MODE=onprem` in a file named `.env` in the server folder; the licence is then read from `server/data/license.lic`. A new licence file is produced with:

```
npm run sign-licence
```

The administrator can upload a licence file in Administration › Licence. The application warns 30 days before expiry and becomes read-only when the licence has expired.

8.3 AI features

All AI features work without internet and without any key: a built-in engine produces the suggestions from the organization's own records. A user may optionally connect a live language model in Settings › AI model. The key stays in that user's browser and is sent only with that user's own requests.

9. Production mode (optional)

To run everything from one address, build the screens once and start the server in production mode:

```
cd web
npm run build
cd ../server
npm start
```

Open <http://localhost:4000>. The server now also serves the screens. Before a real deployment, set a private `JWT_SECRET` and `LICENSE_HMAC_SECRET` in `server/.env`.

Setting (server/.env)	Default	Purpose
PORT	4000	Port of the server
DEPLOYMENT_MODE	saas	saas or onprem (licence provider)
DATA_DIR	server/data	Where the data, backups and attachments are kept
JWT_SECRET	development value	Signs the sign-in tokens — change it in production
BACKUP_RETENTION_DAYS	14	How long backups are kept
CORS_ORIGIN	*	Allowed web addresses

9.1 Questionnaire channels: e-mail and WhatsApp

Questionnaire invitations and reminders go out by e-mail (SMTP) and WhatsApp (WhatsApp Business Cloud API). Each organization can enter its own providers in Administration > Channels; the settings below give a platform default used by organizations that have none. Without any provider, messages are kept in the outbox (sandbox) and nothing is sent.

Setting (server/.env)	Default	Purpose
PUBLIC_URL	address of the request	Public address of the application, used in the personal links sent to respondents (for example https://skills.example.com)
CHANNEL_SECRET_KEY	JWT_SECRET	Key that encrypts the channel passwords and tokens (AES-256-GCM) — set a long private value and keep it
SMTP_HOST, SMTP_PORT	—, 587	Mail server and port
SMTP_SECURE	false	true for TLS from the start (port 465)
SMTP_USER, SMTP_PASS	—	Mail account
SMTP_FROM	—	Sender address shown to respondents
WHATSAPP_TOKEN	—	Access token of the WhatsApp Business app
WHATSAPP_PHONE_NUMBER_ID	—	Phone number ID from Meta > WhatsApp > API setup
WHATSAPP_TEMPLATE, WHATSAPP_TEMPLATE_LANG	—	Approved message template used for the first contact, and its language code
WHATSAPP_VERIFY_TOKEN	—	Token you choose and type in Meta when declaring the webhook

Setting (server/.env)	Default	Purpose
WHATSAPP_APP_SECRET	—	App secret used to check the signature of webhook calls
WHATSAPP_API_BASE	https://graph.facebook.com/v21.0	Cloud API address

Declare the webhook <PUBLIC_URL>/api/public/whatsapp/webhook in Meta so delivery statuses (sent, delivered, read, failed) and replies come back. The server retries failed messages every minute and plays due reminders every 10 minutes.

10. If something goes wrong

Message or symptom	What to do
“CortexSkills needs Node.js 22.13 or newer”	Install the LTS version from nodejs.org (section 2), close the window, open a new one and try again.
“Port 4000 is already in use”	CortexSkills is probably already running in another window. Close it, or start on another port (set <code>PORT=4001</code> on Windows, <code>export PORT=4001</code> on macOS/Linux).
“The database is empty”	Run <code>npm run seed</code> in the server folder, then <code>npm run dev</code> .
“npm is not recognized” / “command not found”	Node.js is not installed or the window was opened before the installation. Install Node.js, then open a new window.
The browser shows “This site can’t be reached”	Check that both windows are still open and show no error. The address is <code>http://localhost:5173</code> .
Sign-in says “Email or password is incorrect”	Check the password (it is case-sensitive). If you changed the data, run <code>npm run seed</code> to restore the demonstration accounts.
“Too many attempts”	Wait 15 minutes; sign-in is limited to protect accounts.